Westbrook City Council

~ Special Meeting ~

Date: Monday, April 27, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1187109692
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_04272026-1002

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Council Messages & First Public Comment

Documentary Screening, Safe Streets Grant Question & Recreation-Area Security

[1:36]

Discussion Summary

Vice President Shaughnessy, the City's Portland Water District representative, promoted a documentary screening ("Unless Something Goes Terribly Wrong," May 13, Performing Arts Center) about the District's wastewater treatment facility. Councilor McCambridge asked why the City hadn't applied for federal Safe Streets for All grant funding; Director Dudley said the City lacked a sufficiently developed project to submit this cycle.

In public comment, Larry McWilliams followed up on a recreation-area vandalism issue (youths reportedly throwing rocks at basketball courts); Mayor Morse confirmed a mobile surveillance unit deployed about two weeks prior has had a noticeable deterrent effect, with permanent lighting still a longer-term goal.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Unfinished Business

Fowl & Poultry Ordinance — Remains Tabled [7:14]

Discussion Summary

City Administrator Holmes asked the Council to take no action and leave the rooster ordinance (tabled Apr. 6 over a drafting ambiguity) tabled, so staff can bring redrafted language to the next meeting.

Key Decisions

✓ **No action taken; item remains tabled.**

Action Items
None.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2026-39, -40, -41 — Calpine Donation, Stretcher & Canal School Bonds (Consent) [7:55]

Discussion Summary
All first-read at the Apr. 6, 2026 meeting: the $30,000 Calpine Energy confined-space-rescue donation, the $42,987.63 Stryker Power-Load stretcher, and up to $428,445 in bonds for Canal Elementary HVAC — see that meeting's summary for full detail.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed together by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-42 — Land Use Ordinance — Child Care Uses (Second & Final Reading) [9:49]

Found on page 43 of the packet. Public hearing held.

Discussion Summary
Amends the Land Use Ordinance to comply with new state child-care law and permit daycares in all residentially-zoned districts; first-read Apr. 6. Assistant City Administrator Franceschi gave a brief recap. Public hearing held with no public comment.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

FY2026-2027 Budget: First Reading

[12:46] ***Order 2026-44 (Community Center bus):*** *authorizes $122,845 to Quality Van Sales, Inc. for a new 27/28-passenger Ford E-450 bus, replacing a 10-year-old, ~115,000-mile bus in active use 114 of 168 open weekdays this year (58 adult trips, 14 youth programs, per Director Greg Post). The City switched from a planned 5-year lease (~$26,170/year) to an outright purchase as more economical, after a $7,000 trade-in credit and $800 discount. Passed unanimously, first reading.*

Order 2026-45 (the budget itself): because the bus purchase passed, the Council first adopted a floor amendment reflecting the $26,170 reduction in municipal tax need — **passed 5–1 by roll call (Councilor Rairdon opposed)**. As amended:

• Total appropriation: **$106,543,473** (reduced from $106,569,643)
• Municipal operating expenses: **$39,021,807** (reduced from $39,047,977)
• Net budget to be raised and assessed: **$61,666,487** (reduced from $61,692,657)

• Resulting property tax rate increase: an estimated **7.61%** (reduced from 7.65% pre-amendment) — combining a 6.37% municipal expenditure increase, 7.24%/6.06% school (PreK-12/Adult Ed) increases, a 6.62% TIF transfer increase, and a 12.37% Cumberland County assessment increase. (These are the Finance-Committee-refined figures; see the Apr. 6 meeting summary for the Mayor's earlier, higher preliminary estimate.)

The budget as amended **passed first reading, 5–1 (Rairdon opposed)**, by show of hands.

> *"I appreciate the creativity of our departments... You have all provided thoughtful and informative presentations. And some of you have been met with hostility and accusations, and that's not fair to you... If you are over the age of 65 in this community and have lived here for more than eight years, please look at [the senior tax credit]. Being eligible for up to $1,000 will help offset the increase from this year and some of last year's."*

— President Jennifer Munro [25:25]

> *"As we started the budget season... the word that I used to describe this was staggering... We're going from $57,292,671 to $61,666,487. That is $4,373,816... 7.63 percent. This is not sustainable... I question what is want and what is needs. And we cannot continue at this rate... I will not be supporting either budget[]."*

— Councilor Gary Rairdon (dissenting) [31:02]

Key Decisions

✓ Order 2026-44 (bus purchase) passed unanimously, first reading.

✓ Budget amendment passed 5–1 (Rairdon opposed).

✓ Order 2026-45 (FY27 budget, as amended) passed first reading, 5–1 (Rairdon opposed).

✓ Order 2026-46 (School budget warrants) passed [35:00] 5–1 (Rairdon opposed). School Budget goes to voters at the June 9, 2026 referendum.

✓ Order 2026-47 (Wastewater budget: $6,779,069 total, incl. $4,829,623 Portland Water District assessment and $5,994,765 sewer assessment; sewer rate up from $7.73 to $8.35/HCF for CY2027) passed [37:53] unanimously, 6–0 — Rairdon supported this item despite opposing the general budget.

Remaining Orders (2026-48 through 2026-54)

Order 2026-48 — 2026-27 Paving Services Bid [38:06]

Found on page 73 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Awards the paving services bid to Dayton Sand & Gravel Company for the 2026-2027 paving seasons, at the attached unit prices.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-49 — Route 302 & East Bridge Street Intersection Design [39:15]

Found on page 82 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Awards a $40,175 bid to Sebago Technics for intersection signalization and pedestrian-safety design — a ~$500,000 project, half grant-funded ($250,000 outside the City). Director Dudley noted this and Order 2026-50 together bring roughly $1 million in outside safety-improvement funding, including new crosswalks and bike-lane shoulders.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-50 — Saco Street Roadway Improvements [42:20]

Found on page 137 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Awards a $1,712,585 bid to Coastal Road Repair, LLC (milling/paving and sidewalk improvements, Spiller Drive to William Clarke Drive), funded through a MaineDOT Municipal Partnership Initiative.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-51 — Sewer Assessment Software [43:24]

Found on page 154 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes $15,000 for SewerAI (Walnut Creek, CA) sewer/stormwater inspection data-management software and adds the vendor to the sewer fund's annual vendor list; Councilor McCambridge confirmed this is a one-year evaluation, not a multi-year commitment.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-52 — Public Safety Building LED Lighting Upgrade [46:32]

Found on page 162 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes $18,533.81 ($7,500 to Corey Electric, $11,033.81 to Gilman Electric) to complete an LED conversion of all 537 original fluorescent fixtures, expected to reduce both electricity and fixture-repair costs (precise savings difficult to isolate given separate solar-credit accounting from the Rocky Hill Landfill solar array).

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-53 — Lincoln Street & Mayberry Road Cost-Sharing Agreement [50:41]

Found on page 165 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a cost-sharing agreement with WORG, LLC (developer of the River Meadow residential project) — roughly 53% city/47% WORG — covering storm drain work, roadway reclamation, and sidewalks; construction is already underway, with the City administering the contract.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-54 — Saccarappa Park Revitalization Funding [58:04]

Found on page 183 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Accepts $1,000,000 from the Westbrook Environmental Improvement Corporation (WEIC) and $500,000 from the Cornelia Warren Community Association toward the Saccarappa Park Revitalization Project, plus an additional $50,000 and extended performance period under the Maine DECD Brownfields grant (amending Order 2024-47).

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Public Comment (Second): Pedestrian Safety & Budget Pushback

[1:00:49] Two residents raised pedestrian-crossing safety concerns at length, prompting an extended engineering discussion with Director Eric Dudley.

> *"That pedestrian alert lighting would at least give the driver the sense that somebody pressed the button and somebody was trying to walk across that street... I have a 16-year-old daughter that is tasked with walking to school."*

— Josh Blanchard (70 New Gorham Rd., public comment) [1:01:55]

Dudley explained the William Clark Drive/New Gorham Road and Hannaford crossings are governed by federal/state engineering standards (FHWA, ITE, AASHTO) that currently limit some requested fixes, and that a prior grant application to relocate the Hannaford crosswalk (~$250,000) was unsuccessful on competitive scoring. He said he'd explore nighttime "halo" lighting and consider folding a design study for both locations into the Order 2026-49 Sebago Technics contract. Councilors Turcotte, Shaughnessy, and Munro all voiced personal concern about these crossings as parents/residents of the area.

Resident Ken Fawson (91 North St.) raised a neighborhood speeding/traffic-calming request (citing a child struck by a car roughly eight months prior) and a pointed budget critique, comparing Westbrook's proposed 7.65% property tax increase against his prior North Carolina home's taxes and state school rankings.

> *“This budget doesn't pass the [sniff] test... I agree with Mr. Rairdon. You guys really need to sharpen your pencils because I don't think this is going to pass with the citizens.”*

— Ken Fawson (public comment) [1:26:33]

Vice President Shaughnessy responded that North Carolina's stronger county-government structure makes direct comparisons difficult. Resident Steve Pulsoni separately cited an October 2025 Axios report ranking Maine's five-year electricity price increase highest in the nation (67.4%, with 36% in 2024 alone), encouraging the City to pursue solar/LED savings wherever possible. A resident also read aloud an unrelated email from a state representative publicizing an April 29 State House rally in support of LD 127, a child-welfare bill, unconnected to city business.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no votes taken on this public comment.

Closing

Committee Reports & Executive Session [1:30:47]

Discussion Summary

No committee report updates. Council voted to enter executive session under 1 M.R.S. §405(6)(E) (attorney consultation on legal rights, duties, or pending/contemplated litigation), with the Mayor, City Administrator, Assistant City Administrator, City Clerk, Interim and Deputy Directors of Economic Development, Project Manager, and legal counsel invited to attend; the transcript ends there.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to enter executive session approved by show of hands.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com